

ANI

CONSENSUS CALL

With the BJP losing its majority, the parliamentary affairs ministry has to navigate the increased Opposition strength and unpredictable allies to ensure smooth functioning of the House

By KAUSHIK DEKA

The monsoon session of Parliament is here, but the heat of the summer of 2024 will stay a while as Opposition benches become fuller this parliamentary term. Kiren Rijiju then may have his hands very full as he shepherds what is a nodal ministry for the smooth functioning of the government's legislative business. He will have to coordinate not just with the various ministries and departments but also with the different parties in the Opposition, which have returned with better numbers. Their brute majority in the first two terms in the Lok Sabha had enabled the BJP to ride roughshod over Opposition protests on contentious issues and legislations. In its third term, though, the government will not only have to take along Opposition opinion but also mind the interests of its unpredictable allies, particularly the JD(U) and TDP, on whom it depends for survival. In this changed scenario, it will be the remit of the parliamentary affairs minister to forge consensus and ensure that Parliament does what it is mandated to do—discuss, debate and make laws—sans impasse. The ministry's first challenge should come soon, in the upcoming budget session, as Opposition parties prepare to demand a joint parliamentary committee probe into allegations of a stockmarket "scam", in which the Congress claims the prime minister and the Union home minister are involved. Expect enough excitement and for Rijiju a job requiring his best conciliatory skills. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

WORK WITH CONSENSUS
Ensuring parliamentary productivity rises with healthy dialogue between the government and the Opposition

BE CONCILIATORY
In the past two Lok Sabha terms, only a handful of bills were sent to standing committees. That trend needs a strict reversal

KIREN RIJIJU, *52* | BJP
Minister of Parliamentary Affairs

A good start Born in the West Kameng district of Arunachal Pradesh, Rijiju earned his B.A. and LL.B. from the University of Delhi. His father Rinchin Kharu was the first pro-tem speaker of the state

Illustrious rise Over the past decade, Rijiju has emerged as one of the most prominent leaders from the North-east on the national stage. The four-time MP began as the MoS (Home) in 2014 before assuming the role of sports minister. Kiren's visibility further rose when he was appointed law minister in 2021, though he exited in under two years

Ministers of State

ARJUN RAM MEGHWAL, *70* | BJP
Also MoS for Law & Justice



L. MURUGAN, *47* | BJP

Southern saviour Born in Tamil Nadu to Telugu-speaking farmer parents, he was an active member of the ABVP. The Rajya Sabha member from Madhya Pradesh is the BJP's Dalit face in his state